

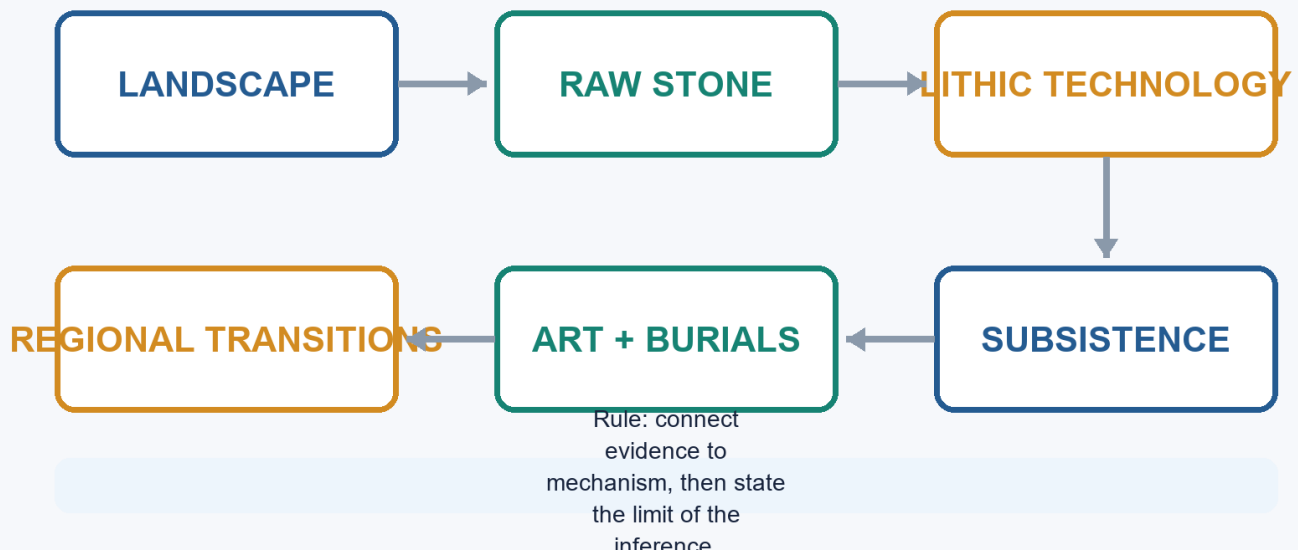
SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

The Stone Age: Palaeolithic & Mesolithic

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

The Stone Age: Palaeolithic & Mesolithic

Evidence-to-explanation learning spine



Original deterministic study visual; labels are explanatory, not textual quotations.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

CONTENTS / WORKBOOK INDEX

Major learning parts and meaningful subtopics are listed in document order. Page numbers are generated from the final PDF layout; PDF bookmarks mirror the same hierarchy.

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The Stone Age: Palaeolithic & Mesolithic - Learner-v2

Complete Learning Session

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

Diagnostic and repair protocol

- Attempt before reading the explanation.
- Classify each error as chronology, evidence, identity, causation, region or overclaim.
- The original answer sequence is preserved and must remain strict A -> B -> C -> D.

MCQ 1

PRE-TEACH CHECKLIST / CURRENT ANCHOR

ORIGINAL UPSC-STYLE PRACTICE. Correct-option rotation follows A -> B -> C -> D without deviation.

The Pleistocene-Holocene distinction is best understood as:

Context: Choose the most appropriate answer.

Visual

EVIDENCE -> CONTEXT -> INTERPRETATION -> QUALIFIED CLAIM

Key Matrix

Option	Statement
A	A geological framework within which cultural phases are studied
B	A sequence of dynasties
C	A pottery classification
D	A script chronology

Core Teaching

- Correct answer: A.
- The Pleistocene and Holocene are geological epochs. Cultural phases overlap their boundary regionally.
- Elimination discipline: identify the phase, evidence type and level of certainty before rejecting close options.

Must-Know Facts

- The Pleistocene and Holocene are geological epochs. Cultural phases overlap their boundary regionally.

UPSC Traps

- **Wrong:** Choose by memorized keyword alone.

Correct: Check chronology, context, overlap and source limitations.

Mains angle: Convert the explanation into one evidence-backed sentence usable in a GS-I answer.

Study link: Relevant teaching card in Part I.

MCQ 2

PRE-TEACH CHECKLIST / CURRENT ANCHOR

ORIGINAL UPSC-STYLE PRACTICE. Correct-option rotation follows A -> B -> C -> D without deviation.

Which statement best describes Indian Stone Age periodization?

Context: Choose the most appropriate answer.

Visual

EVIDENCE -> CONTEXT -> INTERPRETATION -> QUALIFIED CLAIM

Key Matrix

Option	Statement
A	Every phase began simultaneously
B	It is an analytical framework with regional chronological variation
C	It is based only on metal use
D	It identifies biological races

Core Teaching

- Correct answer: B.
- Periodization organizes patterns but does not erase regional overlap or identify a people.
- Elimination discipline: identify the phase, evidence type and level of certainty before rejecting close options.

Must-Know Facts

- Periodization organizes patterns but does not erase regional overlap or identify a people.

UPSC Traps

- **Wrong:** Choose by memorized keyword alone.

Correct: Check chronology, context, overlap and source limitations.

Mains angle: Convert the explanation into one evidence-backed sentence usable in a GS-I answer.

Study link: Relevant teaching card in Part I.

MCQ 3

PRE-TEACH CHECKLIST / CURRENT ANCHOR

ORIGINAL UPSC-STYLE PRACTICE. Correct-option rotation follows A -> B -> C -> D without deviation.

Hathnora is most directly associated with:

Context: Choose the most appropriate answer.

Visual

EVIDENCE -> CONTEXT -> INTERPRETATION -> QUALIFIED CLAIM

Key Matrix

Option	Statement
A	A Mesolithic shell midden
B	A Neolithic village
C	A debated archaic hominin cranial fragment in the Narmada valley
D	A Harappan dock

Core Teaching

- Correct answer: C.
- Hathnora yielded the Narmada cranial fragment with animal fossils and Palaeolithic tools.
- Elimination discipline: identify the phase, evidence type and level of certainty before rejecting close options.

Must-Know Facts

- Hathnora yielded the Narmada cranial fragment with animal fossils and Palaeolithic tools.

UPSC Traps

- **Wrong:** Choose by memorized keyword alone.

Correct: Check chronology, context, overlap and source limitations.

Mains angle: Convert the explanation into one evidence-backed sentence usable in a GS-I answer.

Study link: Relevant teaching card in Part I.

MCQ 4

PRE-TEACH CHECKLIST / CURRENT ANCHOR

ORIGINAL UPSC-STYLE PRACTICE. Correct-option rotation follows A -> B -> C -> D without deviation.

A major lesson from ancient DNA for human evolution is that:

Context: Choose the most appropriate answer.

Visual

EVIDENCE -> CONTEXT -> INTERPRETATION -> QUALIFIED CLAIM

Key Matrix

Option	Statement
A	Every tool type maps to one species
B	Evolution ended with Homo erectus
C	South Asia has no relevance
D	Coexistence, migration and admixture complicate a simple ladder

Core Teaching

- Correct answer: D.
- Ancient DNA supports branching and mixture, not a neat unilinear succession.
- Elimination discipline: identify the phase, evidence type and level of certainty before rejecting close options.

Must-Know Facts

- Ancient DNA supports branching and mixture, not a neat unilinear succession.

UPSC Traps

- **Wrong:** Choose by memorized keyword alone.

Correct: Check chronology, context, overlap and source limitations.

Mains angle: Convert the explanation into one evidence-backed sentence usable in a GS-I answer.

Study link: Relevant teaching card in Part I.

MCQ 5

PRE-TEACH CHECKLIST / CURRENT ANCHOR

ORIGINAL UPSC-STYLE PRACTICE. Correct-option rotation follows A -> B -> C -> D without deviation.

Which combination is most characteristic of the Lower Palaeolithic?

Context: Choose the most appropriate answer.

Visual

EVIDENCE -> CONTEXT -> INTERPRETATION -> QUALIFIED CLAIM

Key Matrix

Option	Statement
A	Handaxe-cleaver-chopper
B	Microlith-pottery-sickle
C	Polished celt-plough
D	Iron arrowhead-NBPW

Core Teaching

- Correct answer: A.
- Large cutting tools and core/flake industries are classic Lower Palaeolithic markers.
- Elimination discipline: identify the phase, evidence type and level of certainty before rejecting close options.

Must-Know Facts

- Large cutting tools and core/flake industries are classic Lower Palaeolithic markers.

UPSC Traps

- **Wrong:** Choose by memorized keyword alone.

Correct: Check chronology, context, overlap and source limitations.

Mains angle: Convert the explanation into one evidence-backed sentence usable in a GS-I answer.

Study link: Relevant teaching card in Part I.

MCQ 6

PRE-TEACH CHECKLIST / CURRENT ANCHOR

ORIGINAL UPSC-STYLE PRACTICE. Correct-option rotation follows A -> B -> C -> D without deviation.

Acheulian most accurately refers to:

Context: Choose the most appropriate answer.

Visual

EVIDENCE -> CONTEXT -> INTERPRETATION -> QUALIFIED CLAIM

Key Matrix

Option	Statement
A	Any Stone Age site
B	An assemblage strongly marked by bifacial handaxes and cleavers
C	A Mesolithic burial rite
D	A radiocarbon method

Core Teaching

- Correct answer: B.
- Acheulian is a technological assemblage label, not an ethnicity.
- Elimination discipline: identify the phase, evidence type and level of certainty before rejecting close options.

Must-Know Facts

- Acheulian is a technological assemblage label, not an ethnicity.

UPSC Traps

- **Wrong:** Choose by memorized keyword alone.

Correct: Check chronology, context, overlap and source limitations.

Mains angle: Convert the explanation into one evidence-backed sentence usable in a GS-I answer.

Study link: Relevant teaching card in Part I.

MCQ 7

PRE-TEACH CHECKLIST / CURRENT ANCHOR

ORIGINAL UPSC-STYLE PRACTICE. Correct-option rotation follows A -> B -> C -> D without deviation.

Isampur is especially important because it preserves:

Context: Choose the most appropriate answer.

Visual

EVIDENCE -> CONTEXT -> INTERPRETATION -> QUALIFIED CLAIM

Key Matrix

Option	Statement
A	Only a royal inscription
B	A Buddhist monastery
C	A large tool-manufacture and habitation context
D	A megalithic cemetery

Core Teaching

- Correct answer: C.
- Cores, debitage, unfinished tools and hammerstones reveal quarrying and production.
- Elimination discipline: identify the phase, evidence type and level of certainty before rejecting close options.

Must-Know Facts

- Cores, debitage, unfinished tools and hammerstones reveal quarrying and production.

UPSC Traps

- **Wrong:** Choose by memorized keyword alone.

Correct: Check chronology, context, overlap and source limitations.

Mains angle: Convert the explanation into one evidence-backed sentence usable in a GS-I answer.

Study link: Relevant teaching card in Part I.

MCQ 8

PRE-TEACH CHECKLIST / CURRENT ANCHOR

ORIGINAL UPSC-STYLE PRACTICE. Correct-option rotation follows A -> B -> C -> D without deviation.

Attirampakkam's principal historiographical significance is that it:

Context: Choose the most appropriate answer.

Visual

EVIDENCE -> CONTEXT -> INTERPRETATION -> QUALIFIED CLAIM

Key Matrix

Option	Statement
A	Proves Denisovan occupation
B	Contains the earliest Indian pottery
C	Is a Mesolithic cemetery
D	Provides a deeply dated Acheulian-to-Middle-Palaeolithic sequence

Core Teaching

- Correct answer: D.
- Its site-specific sequence revises rigid all-India chronology.
- Elimination discipline: identify the phase, evidence type and level of certainty before rejecting close options.

Must-Know Facts

- Its site-specific sequence revises rigid all-India chronology.

UPSC Traps

- **Wrong:** Choose by memorized keyword alone.

Correct: Check chronology, context, overlap and source limitations.

Mains angle: Convert the explanation into one evidence-backed sentence usable in a GS-I answer.

Study link: Relevant teaching card in Part I.

MCQ 9

PRE-TEACH CHECKLIST / CURRENT ANCHOR

ORIGINAL UPSC-STYLE PRACTICE. Correct-option rotation follows A -> B -> C -> D without deviation.

The Levallois technique begins with:

Context: Choose the most appropriate answer.

Visual

EVIDENCE -> CONTEXT -> INTERPRETATION -> QUALIFIED CLAIM

Key Matrix

Option	Statement
A	Careful preparation of core convexities and a striking platform
B	Polishing the finished axe
C	Casting a metal mould
D	Grinding a pot

Core Teaching

- Correct answer: A.
- The desired flake is planned through core preparation before detachment.
- Elimination discipline: identify the phase, evidence type and level of certainty before rejecting close options.

Must-Know Facts

- The desired flake is planned through core preparation before detachment.

UPSC Traps

- **Wrong:** Choose by memorized keyword alone.

Correct: Check chronology, context, overlap and source limitations.

Mains angle: Convert the explanation into one evidence-backed sentence usable in a GS-I answer.

Study link: Relevant teaching card in Part I.

MCQ 10

PRE-TEACH CHECKLIST / CURRENT ANCHOR

ORIGINAL UPSC-STYLE PRACTICE. Correct-option rotation follows A -> B -> C -> D without deviation.

The term 'Nevasan industry' is associated mainly with:

Context: Choose the most appropriate answer.

Visual

EVIDENCE -> CONTEXT -> INTERPRETATION -> QUALIFIED CLAIM

Key Matrix

Option	Statement
A	Harappan seals
B	Middle Palaeolithic flake industries of central/peninsular India
C	Mesolithic rock paintings
D	Neolithic pit dwellings

Core Teaching

- Correct answer: B.
- It derives from Nevasa, where stratified Middle Palaeolithic artefacts were studied.
- Elimination discipline: identify the phase, evidence type and level of certainty before rejecting close options.

Must-Know Facts

- It derives from Nevasa, where stratified Middle Palaeolithic artefacts were studied.

UPSC Traps

- **Wrong:** Choose by memorized keyword alone.

Correct: Check chronology, context, overlap and source limitations.

Mains angle: Convert the explanation into one evidence-backed sentence usable in a GS-I answer.

Study link: Relevant teaching card in Part I.

MCQ 11

PRE-TEACH CHECKLIST / CURRENT ANCHOR

ORIGINAL UPSC-STYLE PRACTICE. Correct-option rotation follows A -> B -> C -> D without deviation.

Which pair is most characteristic of the Upper Palaeolithic?

Context: Choose the most appropriate answer.

Visual

EVIDENCE -> CONTEXT -> INTERPRETATION -> QUALIFIED CLAIM

Key Matrix

Option	Statement
A	Handaxe and cleaver only
B	Polished axe and plough
C	Parallel-sided blades and burins
D	Iron sickle and coin

Core Teaching

- Correct answer: C.
- Blades and burins are standard Upper Palaeolithic markers.
- Elimination discipline: identify the phase, evidence type and level of certainty before rejecting close options.

Must-Know Facts

- Blades and burins are standard Upper Palaeolithic markers.

UPSC Traps

- **Wrong:** Choose by memorized keyword alone.

Correct: Check chronology, context, overlap and source limitations.

Mains angle: Convert the explanation into one evidence-backed sentence usable in a GS-I answer.

Study link: Relevant teaching card in Part I.

MCQ 12

PRE-TEACH CHECKLIST / CURRENT ANCHOR

ORIGINAL UPSC-STYLE PRACTICE. Correct-option rotation follows A -> B -> C -> D without deviation.

Kurnool caves are especially significant for Upper Palaeolithic:

Context: Choose the most appropriate answer.

Visual

EVIDENCE -> CONTEXT -> INTERPRETATION -> QUALIFIED CLAIM

Key Matrix

Option	Statement
A	Copper hoards
B	Painted Grey Ware
C	Ashokan edicts
D	Bone tools and rich faunal evidence

Core Teaching

- Correct answer: D.
- Some Kurnool cave assemblages contain a high proportion of bone tools.
- Elimination discipline: identify the phase, evidence type and level of certainty before rejecting close options.

Must-Know Facts

- Some Kurnool cave assemblages contain a high proportion of bone tools.

UPSC Traps

- **Wrong:** Choose by memorized keyword alone.

Correct: Check chronology, context, overlap and source limitations.

Mains angle: Convert the explanation into one evidence-backed sentence usable in a GS-I answer.

Study link: Relevant teaching card in Part I.

MCQ 13

PRE-TEACH CHECKLIST / CURRENT ANCHOR

ORIGINAL UPSC-STYLE PRACTICE. Correct-option rotation follows A -> B -> C -> D without deviation.

Microwear analysis primarily helps archaeologists infer:

Context: Choose the most appropriate answer.

Visual

EVIDENCE -> CONTEXT -> INTERPRETATION -> QUALIFIED CLAIM

Key Matrix

Option	Statement
A	How an edge was used
B	The ruler who owned it
C	The language spoken
D	The exact species of maker

Core Teaching

- Correct answer: A.
- Polish, striation and damage patterns can indicate cutting, scraping, hafting and worked materials.
- Elimination discipline: identify the phase, evidence type and level of certainty before rejecting close options.

Must-Know Facts

- Polish, striation and damage patterns can indicate cutting, scraping, hafting and worked materials.

UPSC Traps

- **Wrong:** Choose by memorized keyword alone.

Correct: Check chronology, context, overlap and source limitations.

Mains angle: Convert the explanation into one evidence-backed sentence usable in a GS-I answer.

Study link: Relevant teaching card in Part I.

MCQ 14

PRE-TEACH CHECKLIST / CURRENT ANCHOR

ORIGINAL UPSC-STYLE PRACTICE. Correct-option rotation follows A -> B -> C -> D without deviation.

Why was chalcedony valued for microliths?

Context: Choose the most appropriate answer.

Visual

EVIDENCE -> CONTEXT -> INTERPRETATION -> QUALIFIED CLAIM

Key Matrix

Option	Statement
A	It is always locally abundant
B	Its fine structure permits controlled production of small standardized tools
C	It proves farming
D	It can be radiocarbon dated

Core Teaching

- Correct answer: B.
- Chalcedony's fracture properties support fine, predictable flaking.
- Elimination discipline: identify the phase, evidence type and level of certainty before rejecting close options.

Must-Know Facts

- Chalcedony's fracture properties support fine, predictable flaking.

UPSC Traps

- **Wrong:** Choose by memorized keyword alone.

Correct: Check chronology, context, overlap and source limitations.

Mains angle: Convert the explanation into one evidence-backed sentence usable in a GS-I answer.

Study link: Relevant teaching card in Part I.

MCQ 15

PRE-TEACH CHECKLIST / CURRENT ANCHOR

ORIGINAL UPSC-STYLE PRACTICE. Correct-option rotation follows A -> B -> C -> D without deviation.

Which context most strongly links an artefact to an activity location?

Context: Choose the most appropriate answer.

Visual

EVIDENCE -> CONTEXT -> INTERPRETATION -> QUALIFIED CLAIM

Key Matrix

Option	Statement
A	Museum collection
B	Unprovenanced market find
C	Primary archaeological context
D	Secondary river gravel

Core Teaching

- Correct answer: C.
- Primary context is least displaced from place of use or manufacture.
- Elimination discipline: identify the phase, evidence type and level of certainty before rejecting close options.

Must-Know Facts

- Primary context is least displaced from place of use or manufacture.

UPSC Traps

- **Wrong:** Choose by memorized keyword alone.

Correct: Check chronology, context, overlap and source limitations.

Mains angle: Convert the explanation into one evidence-backed sentence usable in a GS-I answer.

Study link: Relevant teaching card in Part I.

MCQ 16

PRE-TEACH CHECKLIST / CURRENT ANCHOR

ORIGINAL UPSC-STYLE PRACTICE. Correct-option rotation follows A -> B -> C -> D without deviation.

OSL dating most directly estimates:

Context: Choose the most appropriate answer.

Visual

EVIDENCE -> CONTEXT -> INTERPRETATION -> QUALIFIED CLAIM

Key Matrix

Option	Statement
A	The age of a dynasty
B	The maker's biological species
C	The date paint was imagined
D	The last light exposure of mineral grains

Core Teaching

- Correct answer: D.
- Optically stimulated luminescence dates burial/last light exposure of suitable sediments.
- Elimination discipline: identify the phase, evidence type and level of certainty before rejecting close options.

Must-Know Facts

- Optically stimulated luminescence dates burial/last light exposure of suitable sediments.

UPSC Traps

- **Wrong:** Choose by memorized keyword alone.

Correct: Check chronology, context, overlap and source limitations.

Mains angle: Convert the explanation into one evidence-backed sentence usable in a GS-I answer.

Study link: Relevant teaching card in Part I.

MCQ 17

PRE-TEACH CHECKLIST / CURRENT ANCHOR

ORIGINAL UPSC-STYLE PRACTICE. Correct-option rotation follows A -> B -> C -> D without deviation.

The Mesolithic in India is best described as:

Context: Choose the most appropriate answer.

Visual

EVIDENCE -> CONTEXT -> INTERPRETATION -> QUALIFIED CLAIM

Key Matrix

Option	Statement
A	A regionally variable foraging phase often marked by microliths
B	A uniform full-farming age
C	An iron-using urban phase
D	A textual period

Core Teaching

- Correct answer: A.
- It includes broad-spectrum foraging, variable residence, art and debated domestication.
- Elimination discipline: identify the phase, evidence type and level of certainty before rejecting close options.

Must-Know Facts

- It includes broad-spectrum foraging, variable residence, art and debated domestication.

UPSC Traps

- **Wrong:** Choose by memorized keyword alone.

Correct: Check chronology, context, overlap and source limitations.

Mains angle: Convert the explanation into one evidence-backed sentence usable in a GS-I answer.

Study link: Relevant teaching card in Part I.

MCQ 18

PRE-TEACH CHECKLIST / CURRENT ANCHOR

ORIGINAL UPSC-STYLE PRACTICE. Correct-option rotation follows A -> B -> C -> D without deviation.

A microlith is generally:

Context: Choose the most appropriate answer.

Visual

EVIDENCE -> CONTEXT -> INTERPRETATION -> QUALIFIED CLAIM

Key Matrix

Option	Statement
A	A polished celt over 20 cm
B	A small blade-based stone element often under 5 cm
C	A copper axe
D	A fossil

Core Teaching

- Correct answer: B.
- Microliths include geometric and non-geometric small inserts.
- Elimination discipline: identify the phase, evidence type and level of certainty before rejecting close options.

Must-Know Facts

- Microliths include geometric and non-geometric small inserts.

UPSC Traps

- **Wrong:** Choose by memorized keyword alone.

Correct: Check chronology, context, overlap and source limitations.

Mains angle: Convert the explanation into one evidence-backed sentence usable in a GS-I answer.

Study link: Relevant teaching card in Part I.

MCQ 19

PRE-TEACH CHECKLIST / CURRENT ANCHOR

ORIGINAL UPSC-STYLE PRACTICE. Correct-option rotation follows A -> B -> C -> D without deviation.

The strongest functional interpretation of many microliths is that they were:

Context: Choose the most appropriate answer.

Visual

EVIDENCE -> CONTEXT -> INTERPRETATION -> QUALIFIED CLAIM

Key Matrix

Option	Statement
A	Coins
B	Pottery stamps
C	Mounted as replaceable elements in composite tools
D	Writing implements

Core Teaching

- Correct answer: C.
- Hafting turns small inserts into arrows, knives, sickles, spears and harpoons.
- Elimination discipline: identify the phase, evidence type and level of certainty before rejecting close options.

Must-Know Facts

- Hafting turns small inserts into arrows, knives, sickles, spears and harpoons.

UPSC Traps

- **Wrong:** Choose by memorized keyword alone.

Correct: Check chronology, context, overlap and source limitations.

Mains angle: Convert the explanation into one evidence-backed sentence usable in a GS-I answer.

Study link: Relevant teaching card in Part I.

MCQ 20

PRE-TEACH CHECKLIST / CURRENT ANCHOR

ORIGINAL UPSC-STYLE PRACTICE. Correct-option rotation follows A -> B -> C -> D without deviation.

Epi-Palaeolithic is sometimes used for:

Context: Choose the most appropriate answer.

Visual

EVIDENCE -> CONTEXT -> INTERPRETATION -> QUALIFIED CLAIM

Key Matrix

Option	Statement
A	The Mature Harappan
B	The Iron Age
C	The historic survival of celts
D	A transitional toolkit between Upper Palaeolithic and classic microlithic forms

Core Teaching

- Correct answer: D.
- The term identifies a transitional technological range, not a universal phase.
- Elimination discipline: identify the phase, evidence type and level of certainty before rejecting close options.

Must-Know Facts

- The term identifies a transitional technological range, not a universal phase.

UPSC Traps

- **Wrong:** Choose by memorized keyword alone.

Correct: Check chronology, context, overlap and source limitations.

Mains angle: Convert the explanation into one evidence-backed sentence usable in a GS-I answer.

Study link: Relevant teaching card in Part I.

MCQ 21

PRE-TEACH CHECKLIST / CURRENT ANCHOR

ORIGINAL UPSC-STYLE PRACTICE. Correct-option rotation follows A -> B -> C -> D without deviation.

Chopani Mando is important for:

Context: Choose the most appropriate answer.

Visual

EVIDENCE -> CONTEXT -> INTERPRETATION -> QUALIFIED CLAIM

Key Matrix

Option	Statement
A	A sequence from epi-Palaeolithic/Mesolithic toward huts, pottery and intensified processing
B	An Acheulian-only factory
C	A Mauryan inscription
D	A medieval port

Core Teaching

- Correct answer: A.
- Its deposits document huts, hearths, microliths, pottery and wild-rice evidence.
- Elimination discipline: identify the phase, evidence type and level of certainty before rejecting close options.

Must-Know Facts

- Its deposits document huts, hearths, microliths, pottery and wild-rice evidence.

UPSC Traps

- **Wrong:** Choose by memorized keyword alone.

Correct: Check chronology, context, overlap and source limitations.

Mains angle: Convert the explanation into one evidence-backed sentence usable in a GS-I answer.

Study link: Relevant teaching card in Part I.

MCQ 22

PRE-TEACH CHECKLIST / CURRENT ANCHOR

ORIGINAL UPSC-STYLE PRACTICE. Correct-option rotation follows A -> B -> C -> D without deviation.

Bagor is best known for combining:

Context: Choose the most appropriate answer.

Visual

EVIDENCE -> CONTEXT -> INTERPRETATION -> QUALIFIED CLAIM

Key Matrix

Option	Statement
A	Only Palaeolithic bifaces
B	Microliths, long occupation, subsistence evidence and raw-material mobility
C	A Gupta temple
D	A cave inscription

Core Teaching

- Correct answer: B.
- Bagor is a key Mesolithic sequence with continuing microliths and debated domestication.
- Elimination discipline: identify the phase, evidence type and level of certainty before rejecting close options.

Must-Know Facts

- Bagor is a key Mesolithic sequence with continuing microliths and debated domestication.

UPSC Traps

- **Wrong:** Choose by memorized keyword alone.

Correct: Check chronology, context, overlap and source limitations.

Mains angle: Convert the explanation into one evidence-backed sentence usable in a GS-I answer.

Study link: Relevant teaching card in Part I.

MCQ 23

PRE-TEACH CHECKLIST / CURRENT ANCHOR

ORIGINAL UPSC-STYLE PRACTICE. Correct-option rotation follows A -> B -> C -> D without deviation.

Sarai Nahar Rai is especially associated with:

Context: Choose the most appropriate answer.

Visual

EVIDENCE -> CONTEXT -> INTERPRETATION -> QUALIFIED CLAIM

Key Matrix

Option	Statement
A	Lower Palaeolithic quarrying
B	Harappan weights
C	Mesolithic burials, aquatic resources and an embedded projectile injury
D	Neolithic ash mounds

Core Teaching

- Correct answer: C.
- Its habitation-burial context is central to Ganga-valley Mesolithic studies.
- Elimination discipline: identify the phase, evidence type and level of certainty before rejecting close options.

Must-Know Facts

- Its habitation-burial context is central to Ganga-valley Mesolithic studies.

UPSC Traps

- **Wrong:** Choose by memorized keyword alone.

Correct: Check chronology, context, overlap and source limitations.

Mains angle: Convert the explanation into one evidence-backed sentence usable in a GS-I answer.

Study link: Relevant teaching card in Part I.

MCQ 24

PRE-TEACH CHECKLIST / CURRENT ANCHOR

ORIGINAL UPSC-STYLE PRACTICE. Correct-option rotation follows A -> B -> C -> D without deviation.

Damdama yielded:

Context: Choose the most appropriate answer.

Visual

EVIDENCE -> CONTEXT -> INTERPRETATION -> QUALIFIED CLAIM

Key Matrix

Option	Statement
A	Only surface handaxes
B	No burials
C	A rock edict
D	Numerous burials, hearths, microliths and food-processing evidence

Core Teaching

- Correct answer: D.
- Damdama's thick occupation and 41 burials support longer residence.
- Elimination discipline: identify the phase, evidence type and level of certainty before rejecting close options.

Must-Know Facts

- Damdama's thick occupation and 41 burials support longer residence.

UPSC Traps

- **Wrong:** Choose by memorized keyword alone.

Correct: Check chronology, context, overlap and source limitations.

Mains angle: Convert the explanation into one evidence-backed sentence usable in a GS-I answer.

Study link: Relevant teaching card in Part I.

MCQ 25

PRE-TEACH CHECKLIST / CURRENT ANCHOR

ORIGINAL UPSC-STYLE PRACTICE. Correct-option rotation follows A -> B -> C -> D without deviation.

Formal Mesolithic cemeteries may be linked analytically to:

Context: Choose the most appropriate answer.

Visual

EVIDENCE -> CONTEXT -> INTERPRETATION -> QUALIFIED CLAIM

Key Matrix

Option	Statement
A	Corporate memory and claims over reliable resources
B	Imperial taxation
C	Coin circulation
D	Sanskritization

Core Teaching

- Correct answer: A.
- This is an inference, not a directly written rule, and must be stated cautiously.
- Elimination discipline: identify the phase, evidence type and level of certainty before rejecting close options.

Must-Know Facts

- This is an inference, not a directly written rule, and must be stated cautiously.

UPSC Traps

- **Wrong:** Choose by memorized keyword alone.

Correct: Check chronology, context, overlap and source limitations.

Mains angle: Convert the explanation into one evidence-backed sentence usable in a GS-I answer.

Study link: Relevant teaching card in Part I.

MCQ 26

PRE-TEACH CHECKLIST / CURRENT ANCHOR

ORIGINAL UPSC-STYLE PRACTICE. Correct-option rotation follows A -> B -> C -> D without deviation.

The Bagor chalcedony study is used to reconstruct:

Context: Choose the most appropriate answer.

Visual

EVIDENCE -> CONTEXT -> INTERPRETATION -> QUALIFIED CLAIM

Key Matrix

Option	Statement
A	Only pigment colour
B	Procurement, seasonal movement and possible exchange
C	The Harappan script
D	Iron smelting

Core Teaching

- Correct answer: B.
- Good-quality chalcedony from distant sources opens alternative mobility and exchange models.
- Elimination discipline: identify the phase, evidence type and level of certainty before rejecting close options.

Must-Know Facts

- Good-quality chalcedony from distant sources opens alternative mobility and exchange models.

UPSC Traps

- **Wrong:** Choose by memorized keyword alone.

Correct: Check chronology, context, overlap and source limitations.

Mains angle: Convert the explanation into one evidence-backed sentence usable in a GS-I answer.

Study link: Relevant teaching card in Part I.

MCQ 27

PRE-TEACH CHECKLIST / CURRENT ANCHOR

ORIGINAL UPSC-STYLE PRACTICE. Correct-option rotation follows A -> B -> C -> D without deviation.

Bhimbetka is exceptional because it combines:

Context: Choose the most appropriate answer.

Visual

EVIDENCE -> CONTEXT -> INTERPRETATION -> QUALIFIED CLAIM

Key Matrix

Option	Statement
A	Only medieval paintings
B	Only a burial ground
C	Long occupation, lithics, rock art and heritage significance
D	Only a fossil skull

Core Teaching

- Correct answer: C.
- Its evidence spans Lower Palaeolithic to historical periods.
- Elimination discipline: identify the phase, evidence type and level of certainty before rejecting close options.

Must-Know Facts

- Its evidence spans Lower Palaeolithic to historical periods.

UPSC Traps

- **Wrong:** Choose by memorized keyword alone.

Correct: Check chronology, context, overlap and source limitations.

Mains angle: Convert the explanation into one evidence-backed sentence usable in a GS-I answer.

Study link: Relevant teaching card in Part I.

MCQ 28

PRE-TEACH CHECKLIST / CURRENT ANCHOR

ORIGINAL UPSC-STYLE PRACTICE. Correct-option rotation follows A -> B -> C -> D without deviation.

Which is the best method for dating rock art?

Context: Choose the most appropriate answer.

Visual

EVIDENCE -> CONTEXT -> INTERPRETATION -> QUALIFIED CLAIM

Key Matrix

Option	Statement
A	Style alone in every case
B	Tourist tradition
C	Colour brightness only
D	Multiple methods combining superimposition, context and appropriate scientific dating

Core Teaching

- Correct answer: D.
- Rock-art chronology is strongest when independent approaches converge.
- Elimination discipline: identify the phase, evidence type and level of certainty before rejecting close options.

Must-Know Facts

- Rock-art chronology is strongest when independent approaches converge.

UPSC Traps

- **Wrong:** Choose by memorized keyword alone.

Correct: Check chronology, context, overlap and source limitations.

Mains angle: Convert the explanation into one evidence-backed sentence usable in a GS-I answer.

Study link: Relevant teaching card in Part I.

MCQ 29

PRE-TEACH CHECKLIST / CURRENT ANCHOR

ORIGINAL UPSC-STYLE PRACTICE. Correct-option rotation follows A -> B -> C -> D without deviation.

Which site-region pair is correctly matched?

Context: Choose the most appropriate answer.

Visual

EVIDENCE -> CONTEXT -> INTERPRETATION -> QUALIFIED CLAIM

Key Matrix

Option	Statement
A	Attirampakkam - Kortallaiyar basin, Tamil Nadu
B	Bagor - Kashmir valley
C	Damdama - Deccan plateau
D	Isampur - Ganga delta

Core Teaching

- Correct answer: A.
- Attirampakkam is a major Tamil Nadu Palaeolithic site.
- Elimination discipline: identify the phase, evidence type and level of certainty before rejecting close options.

Must-Know Facts

- Attirampakkam is a major Tamil Nadu Palaeolithic site.

UPSC Traps

- **Wrong:** Choose by memorized keyword alone.

Correct: Check chronology, context, overlap and source limitations.

Mains angle: Convert the explanation into one evidence-backed sentence usable in a GS-I answer.

Study link: Relevant teaching card in Part I.

MCQ 30

PRE-TEACH CHECKLIST / CURRENT ANCHOR

ORIGINAL UPSC-STYLE PRACTICE. Correct-option rotation follows A -> B -> C -> D without deviation.

Kachchh shell middens are most useful for studying:

Context: Choose the most appropriate answer.

Visual

EVIDENCE -> CONTEXT -> INTERPRETATION -> QUALIFIED CLAIM

Key Matrix

Option	Statement
A	Vedic ritual
B	Early coastal hunter-gatherer diet and adaptation
C	Gupta coinage
D	Chola administration

Core Teaching

- Correct answer: B.
- Discarded shells plus AMS dates illuminate coastal foraging before Harappan urbanism.
- Elimination discipline: identify the phase, evidence type and level of certainty before rejecting close options.

Must-Know Facts

- Discarded shells plus AMS dates illuminate coastal foraging before Harappan urbanism.

UPSC Traps

- **Wrong:** Choose by memorized keyword alone.

Correct: Check chronology, context, overlap and source limitations.

Mains angle: Convert the explanation into one evidence-backed sentence usable in a GS-I answer.

Study link: Relevant teaching card in Part I.

MCQ 31

PRE-TEACH CHECKLIST / CURRENT ANCHOR

ORIGINAL UPSC-STYLE PRACTICE. Correct-option rotation follows A -> B -> C -> D without deviation.

The Retlapalle assemblage is notable for:

Context: Choose the most appropriate answer.

Visual

EVIDENCE -> CONTEXT -> INTERPRETATION -> QUALIFIED CLAIM

Key Matrix

Option	Statement
A	Only polished axes
B	Only rock paintings
C	A dated Middle Palaeolithic assemblage with several formal core strategies
D	A cemetery of 41 burials

Core Teaching

- Correct answer: C.
- The published study records Levallois, discoidal, radial, blade and unidirectional methods.
- Elimination discipline: identify the phase, evidence type and level of certainty before rejecting close options.

Must-Know Facts

- The published study records Levallois, discoidal, radial, blade and unidirectional methods.

UPSC Traps

- **Wrong:** Choose by memorized keyword alone.

Correct: Check chronology, context, overlap and source limitations.

Mains angle: Convert the explanation into one evidence-backed sentence usable in a GS-I answer.

Study link: Relevant teaching card in Part I.

MCQ 32

PRE-TEACH CHECKLIST / CURRENT ANCHOR

ORIGINAL UPSC-STYLE PRACTICE. Correct-option rotation follows A -> B -> C -> D without deviation.

The 2026 Ladakh ancient-genome study should be used in Topic 04 as:

Context: Choose the most appropriate answer.

Visual

EVIDENCE -> CONTEXT -> INTERPRETATION -> QUALIFIED CLAIM

Key Matrix

Option	Statement
A	Direct proof of Palaeolithic ancestry
B	A Stone Age site date
C	A Denisovan fossil from India
D	A methodological current link demonstrating aDNA's potential and chronological limits

Core Teaching

- Correct answer: D.
- The remains are later, but the methods show what genetics can add when suitable material survives.
- Elimination discipline: identify the phase, evidence type and level of certainty before rejecting close options.

Must-Know Facts

- The remains are later, but the methods show what genetics can add when suitable material survives.

UPSC Traps

- **Wrong:** Choose by memorized keyword alone.

Correct: Check chronology, context, overlap and source limitations.

Mains angle: Convert the explanation into one evidence-backed sentence usable in a GS-I answer.

Study link: Relevant teaching card in Part I.

Remedial MCQ 33

PRE-TEACH CHECKLIST / CURRENT ANCHOR

ORIGINAL UPSC-STYLE PRACTICE. Correct-option rotation follows A -> B -> C -> D without deviation.

A handaxe is best classified as:

Context: Choose the most appropriate answer.

Visual

EVIDENCE -> CONTEXT -> INTERPRETATION -> QUALIFIED CLAIM

Key Matrix

Option	Statement
A	Usually a bifacial core tool
B	Always a microlith
C	A polished Neolithic celt
D	A bone tool

Core Teaching

- Correct answer: A.
- Handaxes are generally bifacial large cutting tools; some may have been hafted.
- Elimination discipline: identify the phase, evidence type and level of certainty before rejecting close options.

Must-Know Facts

- Handaxes are generally bifacial large cutting tools; some may have been hafted.

UPSC Traps

- **Wrong:** Choose by memorized keyword alone.

Correct: Check chronology, context, overlap and source limitations.

Mains angle: Convert the explanation into one evidence-backed sentence usable in a GS-I answer.

Study link: Relevant teaching card in Part I.

Remedial MCQ 34

PRE-TEACH CHECKLIST / CURRENT ANCHOR

ORIGINAL UPSC-STYLE PRACTICE. Correct-option rotation follows A -> B -> C -> D without deviation.

Which statement about phase boundaries is correct?

Context: Choose the most appropriate answer.

Visual

EVIDENCE -> CONTEXT -> INTERPRETATION -> QUALIFIED CLAIM

Key Matrix

Option	Statement
A	Every phase replaced the earlier instantly
B	Tools and subsistence practices can overlap across phases
C	Microliths never occur after Mesolithic
D	Pottery always means farming

Core Teaching

- Correct answer: B.
- Overlap is a central corrective to rigid chronology.
- Elimination discipline: identify the phase, evidence type and level of certainty before rejecting close options.

Must-Know Facts

- Overlap is a central corrective to rigid chronology.

UPSC Traps

- **Wrong:** Choose by memorized keyword alone.

Correct: Check chronology, context, overlap and source limitations.

Mains angle: Convert the explanation into one evidence-backed sentence usable in a GS-I answer.

Study link: Relevant teaching card in Part I.

Remedial MCQ 35

PRE-TEACH CHECKLIST / CURRENT ANCHOR

ORIGINAL UPSC-STYLE PRACTICE. Correct-option rotation follows A -> B -> C -> D without deviation.

Which evidence most directly supports a factory site?

Context: Choose the most appropriate answer.

Visual

EVIDENCE -> CONTEXT -> INTERPRETATION -> QUALIFIED CLAIM

Key Matrix

Option	Statement
A	One finished tool
B	A modern village name
C	Cores, rough-outs, hammerstones and dense debitage
D	A painted panel alone

Core Teaching

- Correct answer: C.
- A manufacturing sequence is visible through unfinished stages and waste.
- Elimination discipline: identify the phase, evidence type and level of certainty before rejecting close options.

Must-Know Facts

- A manufacturing sequence is visible through unfinished stages and waste.

UPSC Traps

- **Wrong:** Choose by memorized keyword alone.

Correct: Check chronology, context, overlap and source limitations.

Mains angle: Convert the explanation into one evidence-backed sentence usable in a GS-I answer.

Study link: Relevant teaching card in Part I.

Remedial MCQ 36

PRE-TEACH CHECKLIST / CURRENT ANCHOR

ORIGINAL UPSC-STYLE PRACTICE. Correct-option rotation follows A -> B -> C -> D without deviation.

Which claim about Mesolithic domestication is safest?

Context: Choose the most appropriate answer.

Visual

EVIDENCE -> CONTEXT -> INTERPRETATION -> QUALIFIED CLAIM

Key Matrix

Option	Statement
A	All Indian sites have domestic cattle
B	Adamgarh proves a fixed 5000 BCE date
C	Pottery proves cultivation
D	Some sites report domesticated animals, but identifications and stratigraphy are debated

Core Teaching

- Correct answer: D.
- The evidence is important but not universally accepted.
- Elimination discipline: identify the phase, evidence type and level of certainty before rejecting close options.

Must-Know Facts

- The evidence is important but not universally accepted.

UPSC Traps

- **Wrong:** Choose by memorized keyword alone.

Correct: Check chronology, context, overlap and source limitations.

Mains angle: Convert the explanation into one evidence-backed sentence usable in a GS-I answer.

Study link: Relevant teaching card in Part I.

Remedial MCQ 37

PRE-TEACH CHECKLIST / CURRENT ANCHOR

ORIGINAL UPSC-STYLE PRACTICE. Correct-option rotation follows A -> B -> C -> D without deviation.

A grinding stone at a Mesolithic site proves:

Context: Choose the most appropriate answer.

Visual

EVIDENCE -> CONTEXT -> INTERPRETATION -> QUALIFIED CLAIM

Key Matrix

Option	Statement
A	Processing of material, not necessarily cultivated grain
B	A state granary
C	Iron technology
D	A written language

Core Teaching

- Correct answer: A.
- Wild plant foods and pigments can also be ground.
- Elimination discipline: identify the phase, evidence type and level of certainty before rejecting close options.

Must-Know Facts

- Wild plant foods and pigments can also be ground.

UPSC Traps

- **Wrong:** Choose by memorized keyword alone.

Correct: Check chronology, context, overlap and source limitations.

Mains angle: Convert the explanation into one evidence-backed sentence usable in a GS-I answer.

Study link: Relevant teaching card in Part I.

Remedial MCQ 38

PRE-TEACH CHECKLIST / CURRENT ANCHOR

ORIGINAL UPSC-STYLE PRACTICE. Correct-option rotation follows A -> B -> C -> D without deviation.

Which interpretation of grave goods is most defensible?

Context: Choose the most appropriate answer.

Visual

EVIDENCE -> CONTEXT -> INTERPRETATION -> QUALIFIED CLAIM

Key Matrix

Option	Statement
A	They always prove kingship
B	They may indicate ritual, identity or disposal customs; context is required
C	They are irrelevant
D	They provide an official creed

Core Teaching

- Correct answer: B.
- Mortuary meaning is plural and indirect.
- Elimination discipline: identify the phase, evidence type and level of certainty before rejecting close options.

Must-Know Facts

- Mortuary meaning is plural and indirect.

UPSC Traps

- **Wrong:** Choose by memorized keyword alone.

Correct: Check chronology, context, overlap and source limitations.

Mains angle: Convert the explanation into one evidence-backed sentence usable in a GS-I answer.

Study link: Relevant teaching card in Part I.

Remedial MCQ 39

PRE-TEACH CHECKLIST / CURRENT ANCHOR

ORIGINAL UPSC-STYLE PRACTICE. Correct-option rotation follows A -> B -> C -> D without deviation.

Which source is most useful for distinguishing summer and winter occupation?

Context: Choose the most appropriate answer.

Visual

EVIDENCE -> CONTEXT -> INTERPRETATION -> QUALIFIED CLAIM

Key Matrix

Option	Statement
A	Dynastic list
B	Coin legend
C	Seasonality analysis of animal teeth and faunal age profiles
D	Modern rainfall alone

Core Teaching

- Correct answer: C.
- Birth seasons and tooth age can estimate kill season.
- Elimination discipline: identify the phase, evidence type and level of certainty before rejecting close options.

Must-Know Facts

- Birth seasons and tooth age can estimate kill season.

UPSC Traps

- **Wrong:** Choose by memorized keyword alone.

Correct: Check chronology, context, overlap and source limitations.

Mains angle: Convert the explanation into one evidence-backed sentence usable in a GS-I answer.

Study link: Relevant teaching card in Part I.

Remedial MCQ 40

PRE-TEACH CHECKLIST / CURRENT ANCHOR

ORIGINAL UPSC-STYLE PRACTICE. Correct-option rotation follows A -> B -> C -> D without deviation.

Which conclusion best fits Indian rock art?

Context: Choose the most appropriate answer.

Visual

EVIDENCE -> CONTEXT -> INTERPRETATION -> QUALIFIED CLAIM

Key Matrix

Option	Statement
A	Every motif has one universal meaning
B	All paintings are Upper Palaeolithic
C	Brightness gives an exact date
D	It is a major source for activity and symbolism, but dating and meaning remain constrained

Core Teaching

- Correct answer: D.
- Rock art is evidence-rich but interpretively difficult.
- Elimination discipline: identify the phase, evidence type and level of certainty before rejecting close options.

Must-Know Facts

- Rock art is evidence-rich but interpretively difficult.

UPSC Traps

- **Wrong:** Choose by memorized keyword alone.

Correct: Check chronology, context, overlap and source limitations.

Mains angle: Convert the explanation into one evidence-backed sentence usable in a GS-I answer.

Study link: Relevant teaching card in Part I.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

Verification and answer protocol

- Preserve official-key status exactly; inferred keys remain prominently labelled.
- Every Mains answer must use claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification -> verdict.
- Every solved Mains answer retains its specific Why this earns marks note.

PYQ 1. 2019 Prelims GS-I Q92 - Denisovan

PRE-TEACH CHECKLIST / CURRENT ANCHOR

VERIFIED QUESTION TEXT from the local official 2019 Prelims paper. The official 2019 key is not held locally. The answer below is prominently labelled INFERRED ANSWER - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED.

The word 'Denisovan' is sometimes mentioned in media in reference to:

Context: Options: (A) fossils of a kind of dinosaurs; (B) an early human species; (C) a cave system found in North-East India; (D) a geological period in the history of Indian subcontinent.

Visual

EVIDENCE -> CONTEXT -> INTERPRETATION -> QUALIFIED CLAIM

Key Matrix

Question demand	Answer status	Most defensible answer
Identify a scientific human-evolution term	Official local key unavailable	B - an early human species/population

Core Teaching

- INFERRED ANSWER - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED: B.
- Denisovans are an archaic human population first identified from fragmentary remains and ancient DNA associated with Denisova Cave in Siberia.
- Elimination: dinosaur fossils are palaeontological but unrelated; Denisovan is not an Indian cave system; it is not a geological period.
- Confidence: HIGH, because the term has a stable scientific meaning and the other options are categorically incorrect.
- Examiner-grade learning: distinguish a biological population from the place after which it was named.
- **Why this earns marks:** It identifies the scientific meaning, eliminates every distractor, protects the unavailable official key through an explicit inference label, and adds the crucial limitation that no Denisovan fossil is established from India.

Must-Know Facts

- Denisovan refers to an archaic human population, not a period.
- Ancient DNA has revealed interbreeding among archaic and modern human populations.
- No Denisovan fossil from India is established by the sources used here.

UPSC Traps

- **Wrong:** Denisovan is the cave itself.

Correct: The population is named after Denisova Cave.

- **Wrong:** A species label fixes the maker of Indian stone tools.

Correct: Tool-maker attribution needs fossils or genetic evidence.

Mains angle: The PYQ shows that UPSC can connect Ancient History with current palaeoanthropology and genetics.

Study link: Human-evolution card; aDNA current linkage; source limitations.

Mains 1. Original 10-marker - Lithic Sequence

PRE-TEACH CHECKLIST / CURRENT ANCHOR

ORIGINAL SOLVED MAINS PRACTICE. No UPSC official model answer is claimed.

Explain the technological sequence from Lower Palaeolithic core tools to Mesolithic microlithic composites in India. Answer in 150 words.

Context: Model solution is structured for directive, evidence, qualification and verdict.

Visual

EVIDENCE -> CONTEXT -> INTERPRETATION -> QUALIFIED CLAIM

Key Matrix

Claim	Named evidence	Significance	Limitation
Lower Palaeolithic technology involved planned biface manufacture	Isampur quarry-workshop: limestone slabs, rough-outs, cores, flakes, debitage and hammerstones	Reconstructs the operational chain behind Acheulian handaxes and cleavers	A factory assemblage does not identify the hominin maker
The Middle Palaeolithic reorganized core preparation and blank production	Attirampakkam: decline of bifaces, Levallois flakes/points and a luminescence-dated transition at 385 +/- 64 ka	Demonstrates prepared-core planning and an early regional transition	The date belongs to one stratified sequence, not all India
Upper Palaeolithic and Mesolithic toolkits became lighter and increasingly modular	Bhimbetka: blades followed by a Mesolithic shift toward chalcedony and geometric microliths	Shows miniaturization, raw-material choice and suitability for composite implements	Organic hafts rarely survive; function requires microwear/residue support

Core Teaching

- Demand: define the sequence and explain technological logic, not merely list tools.
- Model answer: Indian lithic change was a rebalancing of reduction strategies, not a ladder from crude to intelligent. At **Isampur**, limestone slabs, rough-outs, debitage and hammerstones reconstruct planned Acheulian manufacture of durable handaxes and cleavers; however, the workshop cannot identify their hominin maker. At **Attirampakkam**, bifaces declined while Levallois flakes and points increased, and luminescence places the Acheulian-Middle Palaeolithic transition at **385 +/- 64 ka**. This proves prepared-core planning and an early south-Indian sequence, not a simultaneous all-India change. At **Bhimbetka**, later blades were followed by greater use of chalcedony and geometric microliths. Such backed inserts suited arrows, knives and other composite implements because a damaged segment could be replaced, although vanished wooden or bone hafts make function partly inferential. Thus, core tools, prepared flakes, blades and microliths overlapped according to task, raw material, mobility and ecology.
- **Why this earns marks:** It answers technological sequence through three diagnostic sites, explains what each assemblage proves, defines Levallois/composite logic, and qualifies chronology, tool-maker attribution and functional inference within 10-marker scale.

Must-Know Facts

- Model introduction: Indian Stone Age technology shows a broad shift from large core/biface equipment to prepared flakes, blades and modular microlithic composites, but the sequence was overlapping and regional.
- Evidence target: three linked sites - Isampur, Attirampakkam and Bhimbetka - with one explicit limitation for each evidentiary move.

UPSC Traps

- **Wrong:** Write a chronology-only answer.

Correct: Explain mechanisms, evidence and debate.

- **Wrong:** Present an inference as settled fact.

Correct: Label and qualify interpretation.

Mains angle: Use the compact sequence manufacture -> prepared core -> blade -> modular insert, while stating that overlap and regional chronologies prevent a simplistic evolutionary ladder.

Study link: Part I teaching cards and final register notes.

Mains 2. Original 10-marker - Mesolithic Transition

PRE-TEACH CHECKLIST / CURRENT ANCHOR

ORIGINAL SOLVED MAINS PRACTICE. No UPSC official model answer is claimed.

Why should the Indian Mesolithic be described as a transitional but not yet uniformly agricultural phase? Answer in 150 words.

Context: Model solution is structured for directive, evidence, qualification and verdict.

Visual

EVIDENCE -> CONTEXT -> INTERPRETATION -> QUALIFIED CLAIM

Key Matrix

Claim	Named evidence	Significance	Limitation
Mesolithic communities intensified residence and food processing	Chopani Mando: 1.55 m epi-Palaeolithic-to-Mesolithic sequence, huts, hearths, querns, pottery and wild-rice evidence	Shows cumulative settlement and processing change	Pottery, querns and wild plants do not by themselves prove cultivation
Some foragers became long-resident, socially anchored wetland communities	Sarai Nahar Rai, Mahadaha and Damdama: habitation, aquatic fauna, cemeteries and stone moved from Vindhyan sources	Links broad-spectrum subsistence, repeated residence, mortuary memory and interaction	Cemetery evidence cannot establish farming or hereditary hierarchy
Food production was not uniform or securely established	Bagor and Adamgarh: reported domestic-animal remains alongside microlithic levels	Indicates possible management and contact with food producers	Species identification, dates and stratigraphic association are disputed

Core Teaching

- Demand: balance continuity in foraging with changes in toolkit, residence and management.
- Model answer: The Indian Mesolithic was transitional because the proportions of technology, mobility and resource use changed, not because every forager became a farmer. At **Chopani Mando**, a 1.55 m sequence from epi-Palaeolithic to Mesolithic levels contains huts, hearths, querns, pottery and wild-rice evidence, showing longer residence and intensified processing; none alone proves cultivation. At **Sarai Nahar Rai, Mahadaha and Damdama**, aquatic fauna, habitation-cemetery overlap and stone transported from the Vindhyas indicate wetland adaptation, social memory and interaction, while faunal specialists do not agree on domestication. **Bagor and Adamgarh** report domestic-animal remains, but species identification, dates and stratigraphic association remain disputed. Hunting, gathering, fishing and wild-plant use therefore remained central. R.S. Sharma's c. 9000-4000 BCE band is useful scaffolding, but microliths begin earlier and persist later regionally. The Mesolithic was thus a mosaic of experimentation, not a uniform agricultural threshold.
- **Why this earns marks:** It directly answers both halves of "transitional but not uniformly agricultural," uses three evidence clusters, separates residence/processing from domestication, and closes with a qualified regional verdict suited to 10 marks.

Must-Know Facts

- Model introduction: The Mesolithic was transitional because post-Pleistocene communities reorganized technology, settlement and resource use; it was not uniformly agricultural because hunting, gathering, fishing and wild-plant use remained fundamental.
- Evidence target: Chopani Mando, the Middle Ganga burial-habitation sites, and the Bagor-Adamgarh domestication debate.

UPSC Traps

- **Wrong:** Write a chronology-only answer.

Correct: Explain mechanisms, evidence and debate.

- **Wrong:** Present an inference as settled fact.

Correct: Label and qualify interpretation.

Mains angle: Define transition as changing combinations of foraging, residence, technology and management rather than the sudden arrival of agriculture.

Study link: Part I teaching cards and final register notes.

Mains 3. Original 15-marker - Ecology and Adaptation

PRE-TEACH CHECKLIST / CURRENT ANCHOR

ORIGINAL SOLVED MAINS PRACTICE. No UPSC official model answer is claimed.

Analyse how climate, ecology and raw-material landscapes shaped Palaeolithic and Mesolithic adaptations in India. Answer in 250 words.

Context: Model solution is structured for directive, evidence, qualification and verdict.

Visual

EVIDENCE -> CONTEXT -> INTERPRETATION -> QUALIFIED CLAIM

Key Matrix

Claim	Named evidence	Significance	Limitation
River and lake histories structured occupation corridors	Soan, Son-Belan and Narmada terrace/alluvial sequences	Water, fauna and exposed stone repeatedly attracted occupation	Erosion and redeposition can separate tools from primary activity surfaces
Aridity changed the density and location of occupations	Didwana/Thar palaeolakes and the reduced Upper Palaeolithic site count in the Thar	Connects rainfall and surface water to mobility and site choice	Survey and preservation bias can imitate demographic decline
Raw-material landscapes shaped manufacture and mobility	Hunsgi-Isampur limestone quarry-workshop complex	Links stone quality, reduction stage and task-specific settlement	Factory and habitation debris may accumulate as a long palimpsest
Wetlands supported broad-spectrum, long-resident foragers	Sarai Nahar Rai, Mahadaha and Damdama: fish/turtle/fauna, burials and Vindhyan stone transport	Shows aquatic subsistence, repeated residence and interaction over distance	Domestic-animal identification and seasonality inferences remain debated
Coasts generated distinctive foraging systems	Kachchh shell middens dated through AMS radiocarbon research	Demonstrates pre-urban marine-resource exploitation	Shell dates require contextual control and possible reservoir-effect caution

Core Teaching

- Demand: show mechanisms and human agency; avoid environmental determinism.
- Model answer: Climate and ecology shaped the distribution of opportunities; they did not mechanically determine behaviour. **Soan, Son-Belan and Narmada** terrace/alluvial sequences show why water, game and exposed raw material repeatedly attracted occupation, but redeposition can move artefacts away from primary activity surfaces. In the **Didwana-Thar** zone, palaeolakes document wetter phases, while fewer Upper Palaeolithic sites coincide with increasing aridity; preservation and survey gaps, however, prevent a simple population-collapse claim. The **Hunsgi-Isampur** complex joined seasonal water, wild foods and workable limestone, producing quarry-workshops and varied camps; its deposits are nevertheless palimpsests of repeated visits. **Bhimbetka** combined perennial water, shelter, edible plants, animals and local quartzite, explaining long reuse, although rock-shelter preservation makes such occupations unusually visible. Early Holocene wetlands supported a different adaptation at **Sarai Nahar Rai, Mahadaha and Damdama**: fish, turtle and other fauna, habitation-cemetery overlap and stone transported from the Vindhyas indicate broad-spectrum subsistence, longer residence and interregional contact, although domestication identifications remain contested. On the coast, **Kachchh shell middens**, dated through AMS radiocarbon research, establish marine-resource use before urbanism, subject to shell-context and reservoir-effect checks. Fine-grained chert and chalcedony further enabled standardized bladelets and portable composite tools. Palaeoenvironment therefore set constraints and incentives, while technical knowledge, mobility, social memory and exchange created regionally different adaptations.

- **Why this earns marks:** It supplies five ecological zones/case studies, repeatedly links environment to a behavioural mechanism, includes raw-material economics, and qualifies geomorphology, survey, faunal and dating evidence rather than lapsing into determinism.

Must-Know Facts

- Model introduction: Pleistocene-Holocene change redistributed water, vegetation, fauna and coastlines, while stone availability structured technology. These conditions shaped opportunity, but knowledge, mobility and social organization converted opportunity into adaptation.
- Evidence target: five region-method units - river terraces, Thar palaeolakes, Hunsgi-Isampur, Middle Ganga wetlands and Kachchh coasts.

UPSC Traps

- **Wrong:** Write a chronology-only answer.

Correct: Explain mechanisms, evidence and debate.

- **Wrong:** Present an inference as settled fact.

Correct: Label and qualify interpretation.

Mains angle: Organize the answer as ecology -> resource distribution -> technological/mobility response -> evidence limit.

Study link: Part I teaching cards and final register notes.

Mains 4. Original 15-marker - Rock Art as Historical Source

PRE-TEACH CHECKLIST / CURRENT ANCHOR

ORIGINAL SOLVED MAINS PRACTICE. No UPSC official model answer is claimed.

Assess the value and limitations of prehistoric rock art for reconstructing Mesolithic life in India. Answer in 250 words.

Context: Model solution is structured for directive, evidence, qualification and verdict.

Visual

EVIDENCE -> CONTEXT -> INTERPRETATION -> QUALIFIED CLAIM

Key Matrix

Claim	Named evidence	Significance	Limitation
Rock art records activities omitted by lithics	Bhimbetka hunting, gathering, food preparation, dance, ornament and masked figures	Opens windows onto subsistence, embodiment, performance and possible social roles	Depictions are selective images, not a census or event transcript
Panel location can reveal collective practice	Large/high Bhimbetka paintings and layered panels in shelters not used primarily for habitation	Labour and repeated repainting may indicate aggregation or ritualized performance	Height and layering do not identify motive or belief
Regional styles challenge one "Mesolithic art" template	Lakhajao/Kathotia figurative activity scenes; Odisha abstract traditions; cattle-heavy Deccan panels	Shows regionally different visual conventions and changing economies	Some Deccan cattle panels are likely agro-pastoral rather than Mesolithic
Relative sequencing is possible	Bhimbetka superimposition, style, technique and associated archaeology	Builds a chronological order where direct dates are rare	Style-date reasoning can become circular
Scientific dating can narrow but not settle age	Pigment/accretion radiocarbon, thermoluminescence, OSL and uranium/thorium approaches	Dates organic pigment or deposits above/below art	Many dates are indirect; binders may not survive and dated accretions need secure relation to the image

Core Teaching

- Demand: evaluate evidence, method and conservation.

- Model answer: Prehistoric rock art is valuable because it depicts behaviour and symbolism that stone-tool typology cannot recover, but it is strongest as contextual rather than literal evidence. At **Bhimbetka**, hunts, gathering, food preparation, dance, ornaments and masked figures reveal activity, movement and visual conventions; they do not identify the artist, audience or exact event. Large paintings on high surfaces and repeated superimposition suggest cooperation and possibly ritualized performance, but labour investment alone cannot prove religion. **Lakhajaoar and Kathotia** add fishing, dancing and food-processing scenes, while abstract traditions in **Odisha** and cattle-heavy panels in the **Deccan** demonstrate regional variation; some Deccan panels, however, may be agro-pastoral rather than Mesolithic. Chronology can be built relatively through superimposition, style, technique and excavated context. Carbon-14 may date organic pigment or accretion, while thermoluminescence, OSL and uranium/thorium can date deposits on the rock surface; these often date a related event, not the painting itself. Kerala shelters assigned stylistically to late Mesolithic phases but lacking associated microliths expose the danger of circular dating. Weathering, visitor contact, water action and conservation treatments can also alter pigment, patina and visibility, so the surviving corpus is not neutral. Rock art therefore illuminates subsistence, social performance and cognition only when triangulated with lithics, stratigraphy, landscape and conservation science.
- **Why this earns marks:** It assesses both value and limitation through five evidence units, uses named regional contrasts, explains relative and scientific dating, and prevents symbolic or chronological overclaiming.

Must-Know Facts

- Model introduction: Rock art is the most vivid source for Mesolithic cognition and activity, but it is selective imagery whose date and meaning must be reconstructed archaeologically.
- Evidence target: Bhimbetka, Lakhajaoar/Kathotia, Odisha-Deccan comparison, one weak-context case and at least two dating approaches.

UPSC Traps

- **Wrong:** Write a chronology-only answer.

Correct: Explain mechanisms, evidence and debate.

- **Wrong:** Present an inference as settled fact.

Correct: Label and qualify interpretation.

Mains angle: Treat image, panel, sequence, landscape and dating as separate evidentiary layers before inferring Mesolithic life.

Study link: Part I teaching cards and final register notes.

Mains 5. Original 20-marker - Regionality and Periodization

PRE-TEACH CHECKLIST / CURRENT ANCHOR

ORIGINAL SOLVED MAINS PRACTICE. No UPSC official model answer is claimed.

A single linear chronology inadequately explains the Palaeolithic-Mesolithic record of the Indian subcontinent. Critically discuss. Answer in 300-350 words.

Context: Model solution is structured for directive, evidence, qualification and verdict.

Visual

EVIDENCE -> CONTEXT -> INTERPRETATION -> QUALIFIED CLAIM

Key Matrix

Claim	Named evidence	Significance	Limitation
Phase boundaries were asynchronous	Attirampakkam: Acheulian-Middle Palaeolithic transition at 385 +/- 64 ka	Revises the old c. 150,000 BCE textbook boundary in one south-Indian sequence	Luminescence range and stratigraphy are site-specific
Acheulian organization varied by landscape	Hunsgi-Isampur limestone quarry-workshop and task-site cluster	Shows procurement, production and mobility rather than one roaming "culture"	Repeated visits create palimpsests; maker remains unknown
Microliths cannot be confined to a Holocene Mesolithic	Jwalapuram Locality 9: more than 53,000 microliths in levels around 35,000 BP	Demonstrates Late Pleistocene microlithic technology	Tool size alone cannot define economy or cultural identity
Central-Indian sequences combine continuity and symbolic evidence	Bhimbetka: long occupation, raw-material shift, geometric microliths and layered art	Links technology, settlement and representation across phases	Individual paintings and occupation events are difficult to correlate
Middle Ganga Mesolithic lifeways differed from mobile-camp stereotypes	Sarai Nahar Rai, Mahadaha and Damdama: wetland fauna, long residence and cemeteries	Reveals aquatic economies, social memory and territorial attachment	Small burial samples cannot establish all social institutions
Semi-arid western India followed another trajectory	Bagor: long sequence, chalcedony procurement and debated domestic fauna	Connects mobility/exchange with a gradual forager-food producer interface	Later-phase mixing and disputed species identifications complicate labels
Coasts preserved specialized adaptations absent inland	Kachchh shell middens with AMS radiocarbon chronology	Adds marine-resource economies to the regional mosaic	Shell context and reservoir effects require control

Core Teaching

- Demand: critique linear chronology and replace it with a regional framework.
- Model answer: The Lower-Middle-Upper Palaeolithic-Mesolithic sequence remains useful as a comparative macro-framework, but it becomes misleading when treated as simultaneous, exclusive or ethnic. First, **Attirampakkam's** stratified luminescence sequence places the Acheulian-Middle Palaeolithic transition at **385 +/- 64 ka**, much earlier than R.S. Sharma's older c. 150,000 BCE textbook boundary; this revises one region, not all India. Second, **Hunsgi-Isampur** represents an Acheulian landscape of limestone quarrying, manufacture and differentiated task sites, whereas the **Soan-Siwalik** record is tied to terraces and recurrent problems of fluvial context. Third, **Jwalapuram Locality 9** has over 53,000 microliths in levels around **35,000 BP**, so microliths cannot be confined to a Holocene Mesolithic. Fourth, **Bhimbetka** combines long occupation, changing raw materials, geometric microliths and layered art, but the dates of individual paintings cannot simply be read from the lithic sequence. Fifth, the rare **Narmada-Hathnora** hominin evidence cannot be mapped neatly onto widespread tool traditions, showing why a techno-complex is not a biological species. Sixth, **Sarai Nahar Rai, Mahadaha and Damdama** reveal wetland subsistence, cemeteries and long residence unlike a universal mobile-camp model; small samples still limit social reconstruction. Seventh, **Bagor** links semi-arid adaptation and chalcedony movement with disputed domestic fauna and later Chalcolithic interaction. Eighth, AMS-dated **Kachchh shell middens** add a coastal hunter-gatherer trajectory, subject to shell-context controls. Across these regions, handaxes can persist beside flake methods, microliths continue into later food-producing contexts, and pottery or domestic-animal claims arrive unevenly. The labels therefore describe dominant archaeological tendencies, not closed stages: answers must distinguish a technology's first appearance, regional dominance and later survival. Periodization remains necessary shorthand, but the defensible method is nested: macro-phase, regional sequence, dated stratum, assemblage and behavioural inference. This retains comparison while accommodating local innovation, interaction, environmental response and preservation bias, explaining variation without abandoning disciplined chronology.
- **Why this earns marks:** It critically retains the utility of periodization while testing it against eight regional cases, precise dates/assemblages and source limits, then offers a usable nested alternative rather than merely rejecting chronology.

Must-Know Facts

- Model introduction: R.S. Sharma's Lower-Middle-Upper Palaeolithic and Mesolithic bands remain useful exam scaffolding, but recent dates and assemblages show asynchronous regional transitions, technological overlap and diverse subsistence.
- Evidence target: five to eight cases distributed across chronology, lithic tradition, settlement, ecology, symbolism and scientific dating.

UPSC Traps

- **Wrong:** Write a chronology-only answer.

Correct: Explain mechanisms, evidence and debate.

- **Wrong:** Present an inference as settled fact.

Correct: Label and qualify interpretation.

Mains angle: Build the verdict as macro-sequence -> regional chronology -> site stratum -> assemblage -> qualified behaviour.

Study link: Part I teaching cards and final register notes.

Mains 6. Original 20-marker - Scientific Archaeology

PRE-TEACH CHECKLIST / CURRENT ANCHOR

ORIGINAL SOLVED MAINS PRACTICE. No UPSC official model answer is claimed.

Evaluate how scientific methods have transformed the study of Indian prehistory without eliminating interpretive uncertainty. Answer in 300-350 words.

Context: Model solution is structured for directive, evidence, qualification and verdict.

Visual

EVIDENCE -> CONTEXT -> INTERPRETATION -> QUALIFIED CLAIM

Key Matrix

Claim	Named evidence/method	Significance	Limitation
Luminescence has revised deep chronology	Attirampakkam OSL-related luminescence sequence; Retlapalle luminescence plus techno-typology	Dates sediment burial/last light and ties chronology to changing reduction systems	Incomplete bleaching, dose history and reworking can distort the dated event
Other chronometers extend beyond radiocarbon	Kurnool cave ESR estimates around 19,224 BP and 16,686 BP	Provides age estimates where suitable charcoal is absent	ESR depends on dose-rate models and sample association
AMS radiocarbon can date subsistence events	Kachchh shell middens	Establishes pre-Harappan coastal foraging through dated food refuse	Marine reservoir effects and old/reworked shell require correction
Functional science moves beyond typology	Baghor III microwear: cutting, scraping, boring, whittling and probable haft-related tasks	Reconstructs tool use, craft and subsistence	Wear traces can be equifinal and affected by post-depositional damage
Bioarchaeology reconstructs bodies and residence	Sarai Nahar Rai, Mahadaha and Damdama burials, trauma, dental/osteoarthritic and seasonality evidence	Connects health, violence, repeated residence and mortuary practice	Small samples, preservation and age/sex estimation constrain generalization
Rock-art science refines relative sequences	Bhimbetka superimposition/context plus pigment/accretion dating options	Separates painting phases and tests stylistic chronology	Most dates are indirect and may date deposits rather than the image
Landscape methods integrate sites with environment	GIS/geomorphology across Hunsgi-Isampur, Didwana and river valleys	Reconstructs raw-material catchments, palaeolakes and mobility systems	Erosion, survey intensity and modern exposure shape site distributions

Core Teaching

- Demand: balance methodological gain against limits.
- Model answer: Scientific archaeology has transformed Indian prehistory from a largely typological sequence into a dated reconstruction of technology, ecology, diet, mobility and bodies; it has not made interpretation automatic. At **Attirampakkam**, luminescence dates sedimentary events associated with a stratified decline in bifaces and rise of Levallois methods, placing the transition at **385 +/- 64 ka**. At **Retlapalle**, luminescence was combined with techno-typology to identify a terminal Middle Pleistocene Middle Palaeolithic assemblage. Both cases revise chronology, but incomplete bleaching, reworking and sample-event mismatch remain risks. **Kurnool** cave ESR estimates around **19,224 BP and 16,686 BP** extend dating where charcoal is scarce, although dose-rate assumptions and association matter. AMS radiocarbon dating of **Kachchh shell middens** establishes coastal food use, subject to calibration, reservoir effects and reworked shell; radiocarbon dates the sampled organism/event, not a stone tool or whole culture. **Baghor III** microwear moves beyond tool labels to cutting, scraping, boring and haft-related tasks, but different actions or post-depositional damage can create similar traces. Zooarchaeology at **Bagor, Adamgarh and the Middle Ganga sites** tests hunting, seasonality and domestication, yet specialists disagree over fragmented wild/domestic taxa and stratigraphic association. At **Sarai Nahar Rai, Mahadaha and Damdama**, osteology, trauma and dental evidence connect burial with health, violence and repeated residence; small samples limit generalization. At **Bhimbetka**, superimposition, excavated context and possible pigment/accretion dating refine the art sequence, yet many dates remain indirect. GIS and geomorphology further link **Hunsgi-Isampur** and **Didwana** to stone, water and palaeolakes, while erosion and survey intensity bias distributions. Even a precise laboratory result becomes historical evidence only when its sample, measured event and association with the assemblage are secure. Replication across dates, deposits and independent proxies remains essential. Scientific methods therefore increase resolution through multi-proxy triangulation; the proper output is a confidence range and a qualified behavioural claim, not a self-explanatory number.
- **Why this earns marks:** It evaluates multiple method-case relationships, states what material/event each method addresses, pairs every gain with a technical or interpretive limitation, and ends with a clear triangulation rule appropriate to a 20-marker.

Must-Know Facts

- Model introduction: Scientific archaeology has converted Indian prehistory from a mainly typological sequence into a dated study of environments, technology, diet, mobility, bodies and ancestry. Yet every method measures a specific sample and event, requiring contextual interpretation.
- Evidence target: five to eight method-case units covering chronology, function, bodies, art and landscape, each with a sample/event limitation.

UPSC Traps

- **Wrong:** Write a chronology-only answer.

Correct: Explain mechanisms, evidence and debate.

- **Wrong:** Present an inference as settled fact.

Correct: Label and qualify interpretation.

Mains angle: Write every method as sample -> measured event -> historical gain -> uncertainty -> corroboration.

Study link: Part I teaching cards and final register notes.